19 And the Levites from the Kohathites and Korahites stood up to praise the LORD, the God of Israel, shouting in a very loud voice. 20 Early in the morning they got up and left for the Wilderness of Tekoa. As they set out, Jehoshaphat stood up and said, "Hear me, O people of Judah and Jerusalem. Believe in the LORD your God, and you will be upheld; believe in His prophets, and you will succeed." 21 Then Jehoshaphat consulted with the people and appointed those who would sing to the LORD and praise the splendor of His holiness. As they went out before the army, they were singing: "Give thanks to the LORD, for His loving devotion endures forever." 22 The moment they began their shouts and praises, the LORD set ambushes against the men of Ammon, Moab, and Mount Seir who had come against Judah, and they were defeated. 23 The Ammonites and Moabites rose up against the inhabitants of Mount Seir, devoting them to destruction. And when they had made an end to the inhabitants of Seir, they helped to destroy one another.

24 When the men of Judah came to a place overlooking the wilderness, they looked for the vast army, but there were only corpses lying on the ground; no one had escaped. 25 Then Jehoshaphat and his people went to carry off the plunder, and they found on the bodies an abundance of goods and valuables—more than they could carry away. They were gathering the plunder for three days because there was so much. 26 On the fourth day they assembled in the Valley of Beracah, where they blessed the LORD. Therefore that place is called the Valley of Beracah to this day. 27 Then all the men of Judah and Jerusalem, with Jehoshaphat at their head, returned joyfully to Jerusalem, for the LORD had made them rejoice over their enemies. 28 So they entered Jerusalem and went into the house of the LORD with harps, lyres, and trumpets. 29 And the fear of God came upon all the kingdoms of the lands when they heard that the LORD had fought against the enemies of Israel. 30 Then Jehoshaphat's kingdom was at peace, for his God had given him rest on every side. 31 So Jehoshaphat reigned over Judah. He was thirty-five years old when he became king, and he reigned in Jerusalem twenty-five years. His mother's name was Azubah daughter of Shilhi. 32 And Jehoshaphat walked in the way of his father Asa and did not turn away from it; he did what was right in the eyes of the LORD. 33 The high places, however, were not removed; the people had not yet set their hearts on the God of their fathers. 34 As for the rest of the acts of Jehoshaphat, from beginning to end, they are indeed written in the Chronicles of Jehu son of Hanani, which are recorded in the Book of the Kings of Israel. 35 Later, Jehoshaphat king of Judah made an alliance with Ahaziah king of Israel, who acted wickedly. 36 They agreed to make ships to go to Tarshish, and these were built in Ezion-geber. 37 Then Eliezer son of Dodavahu of Mareshah prophesied against Jehoshaphat, saying, "Because you have allied yourself with Ahaziah, the LORD has destroyed your works." So the ships were wrecked and were unable to sail to Tarshish.

21 And Jehoshaphat rested with his fathers and was buried with them in the City of David. And his son Jehoram reigned in his place. 2 Jehoram's brothers, the sons of Jehoshaphat, were Azariah, Jehiel, Zechariah, Azariah, Michael, and Shephatiah; these were all sons of Jehoshaphat king of Israel. 3 Their father had given them many gifts of silver and gold and precious things, as well as the fortified cities in Judah; but he gave the kingdom to Jehoram because he was the firstborn. 4 When Jehoram had established himself over his father's kingdom, he strengthened himself by putting to the sword all his brothers along with some of the princes of Israel. 5 Jehoram was thirty-two years old when he became king, and he reigned in Jerusalem eight years. 6 And Jehoram walked in the ways of the kings of Israel, just as the house of Ahab had done. For he married a daughter of Ahab and did evil in the sight of the LORD. 7 Yet the LORD was unwilling to destroy the house of David, because of the covenant He had made with David, and since He had promised to maintain a lamp for David and his descendants forever. 8 In the days of Jehoram, Edom rebelled against the hand of Judah and appointed their own king.

9 So Jehoram crossed into Edom with his officers and all his chariots. When the Edomites surrounded him and his chariot commanders, he rose up and attacked by night. 10 So to this day Edom has been in rebellion against the hand of Judah. Likewise, Libnah rebelled against his rule at the same time, because Jehoram had forsaken the LORD, the God of his fathers. 11 Jehoram had also built high places on the hills of Judah; he had caused the people of Jerusalem to prostitute themselves and had led Judah astray. 12 Then a letter came to Jehoram from Elijah the prophet, which stated: "This is what the LORD, the God of your father David, says: 'You have not walked in the ways of your father Jehoshaphat or of Asa king of Judah,'" 13 but you have walked in the ways of the kings of Israel and have caused Judah and the people of Jerusalem to prostitute themselves, just as the house of Ahab prostituted itself. You have also killed your brothers, your father's family, who were better than you. 14 So behold, the LORD is about to strike your people, your sons, your wives, and all your possessions with a serious blow. 15 "And day after day you yourself will suffer from a severe illness, a disease of your bowels, until it causes your bowels to come out.'" 16 Then the LORD stirred against Jehoram the spirit of the Philistines and Arabs who lived near the Cushites. 17 So they went to war against Judah, invaded it, and carried off all the possessions found in the king's palace, along with his sons and wives; not a son was left to him except Jehoahaz, his youngest. 18 After all this, the LORD afflicted Jehoram with an incurable disease of the bowels. 19 This continued day after day until two full years had passed. Finally, his intestines came out because of his disease, and he died in severe pain. And his people did not make a fire in his honor as they had done for his fathers. 20 Jehoram was thirty-two years old when he became king, and he reigned in Jerusalem eight years. He died, to no one's regret, and was buried in the City of David, but not in the tombs of the kings.

22 Then the people of Jerusalem made Ahaziah, the youngest son of Jehoram, king in his place, since the raiders who had come into the camp with the Arabs had killed all the older sons. So Ahaziah son of Jehoram became king of Judah. 2 Ahaziah was twenty-two years old when he became king, and he reigned in Jerusalem one year. His mother's name was Athaliah, the granddaughter of Omri. 3 Ahaziah also walked in the ways of the house of Ahab, for his mother was his counselor in wickedness. 4 And he did evil in the sight of the LORD, as the house of Ahab had done, for to his destruction they were his counselors after the death of his father. 5 Ahaziah also followed their counsel and went with Joram son of Ahab king of Israel to fight against Hazael king of Aram at Ramoth-gilead. But the Arameans wounded Joram; 6 so he returned to Jezreel to recover from the wounds they had inflicted on him at Ramah when he fought against Hazael king of Aram. Then Ahaziah son of Jehoram king of Judah went down to Jezreel to visit Joram son of Ahab, because Joram had been wounded. 7 Ahaziah's downfall came from God when he went to visit Joram. When Ahaziah arrived, he went out with Joram to meet Jehu son of Nimshi, whom the LORD had anointed to destroy the house of Ahab. 8 So while Jehu was executing judgment on the house of Ahab, he found the rulers of Judah and the sons of Ahaziah's brothers who were serving Ahaziah, and he killed them. 9 Then Jehu looked for Ahaziah, and Jehu's soldiers captured him while he was hiding in Samaria. So Ahaziah was brought to Jehu and put to death. They buried him, for they said, "He is the grandson of Jehoshaphat, who sought the LORD with all his heart." So no one was left from the house of Ahaziah with the strength to rule the kingdom. 10 When Athaliah the mother of Ahaziah saw that her son was dead, she proceeded to annihilate all the royal heirs of the house of Judah. 11 But Jehoshabeath daughter of King Jehoram took Joash son of Ahaziah and stole him away from among the sons of the king who were being murdered, and she put him and his nurse in a bedroom. Because Jehoshabeath, the daughter of King Jehoram and the wife of Jehoiada the priest, was Ahaziah's sister, she hid Joash from Athaliah so that she could not kill him. 12 And Joash remained hidden with them in the house of God for six years while Athaliah ruled the land.

23 Then in the seventh year, Jehoiada strengthened himself and made a covenant with the commanders of hundreds—with Azariah son of Jeroham, Ishmael son of Jehohanan, Azariah son of Obed, Maaseiah son of Adaiah, and Elishaphat son of Zichri. 2 So they went throughout Judah and gathered the Levites from all the cities of Judah and the heads of the families of Israel. And when they came to Jerusalem, 3 the whole assembly made a covenant with the king in the house of God. "Behold, the king's son!" said Jehoiada. "He must reign, just as the LORD promised concerning the descendants of David." 4 This is what you are to do: A third of you priests and Levites who come on duty on the Sabbath shall keep watch at the doors, 5 a third shall be at the royal palace, and a third at the Foundation Gate, while all the others are in the courtyards of the house of the LORD. 6 No one is to enter the house of the LORD except the priests and those Levites who serve; they may enter because they are consecrated, but all the people are to obey the requirement of the LORD.

7 "The Levites must surround the king with weapons in hand, and anyone who enters the temple must be put to death. You must stay close to the king wherever he goes." 8 So the Levites and all Judah did everything that Jehoiada the priest had ordered. Each of them took his men—those coming on duty on the Sabbath and those going off duty—for Jehoiada the priest had not released any of the divisions. 9 Then Jehoiada the priest gave to the commanders of hundreds the spears and the large and small shields of King David that were in the house of God. 10 He stationed all the troops, with their weapons in hand, surrounding the king by the altar and the temple, from the south side to the north side of the temple.

11 Then Jehoiada and his sons brought out the king's son, put the crown on him, presented him with the Testimony, and proclaimed him king. They anointed him and shouted, "Long live the king!" 12 When Athaliah heard the noise of the people running and cheering the king, she went out to them in the house of the LORD. 13 And she looked out and saw the king standing by his pillar at the entrance. The officers and trumpeters were beside the king, and all the people of the land were rejoicing and blowing trumpets, while the singers with musical instruments were leading the praises. Then Athaliah tore her clothes and screamed, "Treason, treason!"

14 And Jehoiada the priest sent out the commanders of hundreds in charge of the army, saying, "Bring her out between the ranks, and put to the sword anyone who follows her." For the priest had said, "She must not be put to death in the house of the LORD." 15 So they seized Athaliah as she reached the entrance of the Horse Gate to the palace grounds, and there they put her to death. 16 Then Jehoiada made a covenant between himself and the king and the people that they would be the LORD's people. 17 So all the people went to the temple of Baal and tore it down. They smashed the altars and idols to pieces and killed Mattan the priest of Baal in front of the altars. 18 Moreover, Jehoiada put the oversight of the house of the LORD into the hands of the Levitical priests, whom David had appointed over the house of the LORD, to offer burnt offerings to the LORD as is written in the Law of Moses, with rejoicing and song, as ordained by David. 19 He stationed gatekeepers at the gates of the house of the LORD, so that nothing unclean could enter for any reason. 20 He also took with him the

commanders of hundreds, the nobles, the rulers of the people, and all the people of the land, and they brought the king down from the house of the LORD and entered the royal palace through the Upper Gate. They seated King Joash on the royal throne, [21] and all the people of the land rejoiced. And the city was quiet, because Athaliah had been put to the sword.

24 Joash was seven years old when he became king, and he reigned in Jerusalem forty years. His mother's name was Zibiah; she was from Beersheba. [2] And Joash did what was right in the eyes of the LORD all the days of Jehoiada the priest. [3] Jehoiada took for him two wives, and he had sons and daughters. [4] Some time later, Joash set his heart on repairing the house of the LORD. [5] So he gathered the priests and Levites and said, "Go out to the cities of Judah and collect the money due annually from all Israel, to repair the house of your God. Do it quickly." The Levites, however, did not make haste. [6] So the king called Jehoiada the high priest and said, "Why have you not required the Levites to bring from Judah and Jerusalem the tax imposed by Moses the servant of the LORD and by the assembly of Israel for the Tent of the Testimony?" [7] For the sons of that wicked woman Athaliah had broken into the house of God and had even used the sacred objects of the house of the LORD for the Baals. [8] At the king's command a chest was made and placed outside, at the gate of the house of the LORD.

[9] And a proclamation was issued in Judah and Jerusalem that they were to bring to the LORD the tax imposed by Moses the servant of God on Israel in the wilderness. [10] All the officers and all the people rejoiced and brought their contributions, and they dropped them in the chest until it was full. [11] Whenever the chest was brought by the Levites to the king's overseers and they saw that there was a large amount of money, the royal scribe and the officer of the high priest would come and empty the chest and carry it back to its place. They did this daily and gathered the money in abundance. [12] Then the king and Jehoiada would give the money to those who supervised the labor on the house of the LORD to hire stonecutters and carpenters to restore the house of the LORD, as well as workers in iron and bronze to repair the house of the LORD.

[13] So the workmen labored, and in their hands the repair work progressed. They restored the house of God according to its specifications, and they reinforced it. [14] When they were finished, they brought the rest of the money to the king and Jehoiada to make with it the articles for the house of the LORD—utensils for the service and for the burnt offerings, dishes, and other objects of gold and silver. Throughout the days of Jehoiada, burnt offerings were presented regularly in the house of the LORD. [15] When Jehoiada was old and full of years, he died at the age of 130. [16] And Jehoiada was buried with the kings in the City of David, because he had done what was good in Israel for God and His temple. [17] After the death of Jehoiada, however, the officials of Judah came and paid homage to the king, and he listened to them.

[18] They abandoned the house of the LORD, the God of their fathers, and served the Asherah poles and idols. So wrath came upon Judah and Jerusalem for this guilt of theirs. [19] Nevertheless, the LORD sent prophets to bring the people back to Him and to testify against them; but they would not listen. [20] Then the Spirit of God came upon Zechariah son of Jehoiada the priest, who stood up before the people and said to them, "This is what God says: 'Why do you transgress the commandments of the LORD so that you cannot prosper? Because you have forsaken the LORD, He has forsaken you.'" [21] But they conspired against Zechariah, and by order of the king, they stoned him in the courtyard of the house of the LORD. [22] Thus King Joash failed to remember the kindness that Zechariah's father Jehoiada had extended to him. Instead, Joash killed Jehoiada's son. As he lay dying, Zechariah said, "May the LORD see this and call you to account." [23] In the spring, the army of Aram went to war against Joash. They entered Judah and Jerusalem and destroyed all the leaders of the people, and they sent all the plunder to their king in Damascus. [24] Although the Aramean army had come with only a few men, the LORD delivered into their hand a very great army. Because Judah had forsaken the LORD, the God of their fathers, judgment was executed on Joash. [25] And when the Arameans had withdrawn, they left Joash severely wounded. His own servants conspired against him for shedding the blood of the son of Jehoiada the priest, and they killed him on his bed. So he died and was buried in the City of David, but not in the tombs of the kings. [26] Those who conspired against Joash were Zabad son of Shimeath the Ammonitess and Jehozabad son of Shimrith the Moabitess. [27] The accounts of the sons of Joash, as well as the many pronouncements about him and about the restoration of the house of God, are indeed written in the Treatise of the Book of the Kings. And his son Amaziah reigned in his place.

25 Amaziah was twenty-five years old when he became king, and he reigned in Jerusalem twenty-nine years. His mother's name was Jehoaddan; she was from Jerusalem. [2] And he did what was right in the eyes of the LORD, but not wholeheartedly. [3] As soon as the kingdom was firmly in his grasp, Amaziah executed the servants who had murdered his father the king. [4] Yet he did not put their sons to death, but acted according to what is written in the Law, in the Book of Moses, where the LORD commanded: "Fathers must not be put to death for their children, and children must not be put to death for their fathers; each is to die for his own sin." [5] Then Amaziah gathered the people of Judah and assigned them according to their families to commanders of thousands and of hundreds. And he numbered those twenty years of age or older throughout Judah and Benjamin and found 300,000 chosen men able to serve in the army, bearing the spear and shield. [6] He also hired 100,000 mighty warriors from Israel for a hundred talents of silver. [7] But a man of God came to him and said, "O king, do not let the army of Israel go with you, for the LORD is not with Israel—not with any of the Ephraimites." [8] "Even if you go and fight bravely in battle, God will make you stumble before the enemy, for God has power to help and power to overthrow."

[9] Amaziah asked the man of God, "What should I do about the hundred talents I have given to the army of Israel?" And the man of God replied, "The LORD is able to give you much more than this." [10] So Amaziah dismissed the troops who had come to him from Ephraim and sent them home. And they were furious with Judah and returned home in great anger. [11] Amaziah, however, summoned his strength and led his troops to the Valley of Salt, where he struck down 10,000 men of Seir, [12] and the army of Judah also captured 10,000 men alive. They took them to the top of a cliff and threw them down so that all were dashed to pieces. [13] Meanwhile the troops that Amaziah had dismissed from battle raided the cities of Judah, from Samaria to Beth-horon. They struck down 3,000 people and carried off a great deal of plunder. [14] When Amaziah returned from the slaughter of the Edomites, he brought back the gods of the Seirites, set them up as his own gods, bowed before them, and burned sacrifices to them. [15] Therefore the anger of the LORD burned against Amaziah, and He sent him a prophet, who said, "Why have you sought this people's gods, which could not deliver them from your hand?" [16] While he was still speaking, the king asked, "Have we made you the counselor to the king? Stop! Why be struck down?" So the prophet stopped, but he said, "I know that God has determined to destroy you, because you have done this and have not heeded my advice." [17] Then Amaziah king of Judah took counsel and sent word to the king of Israel Jehoash son of Jehoahaz, the son of Jehu. "Come, let us meet face to face," he said.

[18] But Jehoash king of Israel replied to Amaziah king of Judah: "A thistle in Lebanon sent a message to a cedar in Lebanon, saying, 'Give your daughter to my son in marriage.' Then a wild beast in Lebanon came along and trampled the thistle." [19] "You have said, 'Look, I have defeated Edom,' and your heart has become proud and boastful. Now stay at home. Why should you stir up trouble so that you fall—you and Judah with you?" [20] But Amaziah would not listen, for this had come from God in order to deliver them into the hand of Jehoash, because they had sought the gods of Edom. [21] So Jehoash king of Israel advanced, and he and Amaziah king of Judah faced each other at Beth-shemesh in Judah. [22] And Judah was routed before Israel, and every man fled to his own home. [23] There at Beth-shemesh, Jehoash king of Israel captured Amaziah king of Judah, the son of Joash, the son of Jehoahaz. Then Jehoash brought him to Jerusalem and broke down the wall of Jerusalem from the Ephraim Gate to the Corner Gate—a section of four hundred cubits. [24] He took all the gold and silver and all the articles found in the house of God with Obed-edom and in the treasuries of the royal palace, as well as some hostages. Then he returned to Samaria. [25] Amaziah son of Joash king of Judah lived for fifteen years after the death of Jehoash son of Jehoahaz king of Israel. [26] As for the rest of the acts of Amaziah, from beginning to end, are they not written in the Book of the Kings of Judah and Israel? [27] From the time that Amaziah turned from following the LORD, a conspiracy was formed against him in Jerusalem, and he fled to Lachish. But men were sent after him to Lachish, and they killed him there. [28] They carried him back on horses and buried him with his fathers in the City of Judah.

26 All the people of Judah took Uzziah, who was sixteen years old, and made him king in place of his father Amaziah. [2] Uzziah was the one who rebuilt Eloth and restored it to Judah after King Amaziah rested with his fathers. [3] Uzziah was sixteen years old when he became king, and he reigned in Jerusalem fifty-two years. His mother's name was Jecoliah; she was from Jerusalem. [4] And he did what was right in the eyes of the LORD, just as his father Amaziah had done. [5] He sought God throughout the days of Zechariah, who instructed him in the fear of God. And as long as he sought the LORD, God gave him success. [6] Uzziah went out to wage war against the Philistines, and he tore down the walls of Gath, Jabneh, and Ashdod. Then he built cities near Ashdod and among the Philistines.

[7] God helped him against the Philistines, against the Arabs living in Gur-baal, and against the Meunites. [8] The Ammonites brought tribute to Uzziah, and his fame spread as far as the border of Egypt, for he had become exceedingly powerful. [9] Uzziah built towers in Jerusalem at the Corner Gate, the Valley Gate, and the angle in the wall, and he fortified them. [10] Since he had much livestock in the foothills and in the plain, he built towers in the desert and dug many cisterns. And since he was a lover of the soil, he had farmers and vinedressers in the hill country and in the fertile fields.

[11] Uzziah had an army ready for battle that went out to war by assigned divisions, as recorded by Jeiel the scribe and Maaseiah the officer under the direction of Hananiah, one of the royal officers. [12] The total number of family leaders of the mighty men of valor was 2,600. [13] Under their authority was an army of 307,500 trained for war, a powerful force to support the king against his enemies. [14] Uzziah supplied the entire army with shields, spears, helmets, armor, bows, and slingstones.

[15] And in Jerusalem he made skillfully designed devices to shoot arrows and catapult large stones from the towers and corners. So his fame spread far and wide, for he was helped tremendously so that he became powerful. [16] But when Uzziah grew powerful, his arrogance led to his own destruction. He was

unfaithful to the LORD his God, for he entered the temple of the LORD to burn incense on the altar of incense. 17 Then Azariah the priest, along with eighty brave priests of the LORD, went in after him. 18 They took their stand against King Uzziah and said, "Uzziah, you have no right to offer incense to the LORD. Only the priests, the descendants of Aaron, are consecrated to burn incense. Leave the sanctuary, for you have acted unfaithfully; you will not receive honor from the LORD God." 19 Uzziah, with a censer in his hand to offer incense, was enraged. But while he raged against the priests in their presence in the house of the LORD before the altar of incense, leprosy broke out on his forehead. 20 When Azariah the chief priest and all the priests turned to him and saw his leprous forehead, they rushed him out. Indeed, he himself hurried to get out, because the LORD had afflicted him. 21 So King Uzziah was a leper until the day of his death. He lived in isolation, leprous and cut off from the house of the LORD, while his son Jotham had charge of the royal palace to govern the people of the land. 22 As for the rest of the acts of Uzziah, from beginning to end, they are recorded by the prophet Isaiah son of Amoz. 23 And Uzziah rested with his fathers and was buried near them in a field of burial that belonged to the kings; for the people said, "He was a leper." And his son Jotham reigned in his place.

27 Jotham was twenty-five years old when he became king, and he reigned in Jerusalem sixteen years. His mother's name was Jerushah daughter of Zadok. 2 And he did what was right in the eyes of the LORD, just as his father Uzziah had done. In addition, he did not enter the temple of the LORD. But the people still behaved corruptly. 3 Jotham rebuilt the Upper Gate of the house of the LORD, and he worked extensively on the wall at the hill of Ophel. 4 He also built cities in the hill country of Judah and fortresses and towers in the forests. 5 Jotham waged war against the king of the Ammonites and defeated them, and that year they gave him a hundred talents of silver, ten thousand cors of wheat, and ten thousand cors of barley. They paid him the same in the second and third years. 6 So Jotham grew powerful because he ordered his ways before the LORD his God. 7 As for the rest of the acts of Jotham, along with all his wars and his ways, they are indeed written in the Book of the Kings of Israel and Judah. 8 He was twenty-five years old when he became king, and he reigned in Jerusalem sixteen years. 9 And Jotham rested with his fathers and was buried in the City of David. And his son Ahaz reigned in his place.

28 Ahaz was twenty years old when he became king, and he reigned in Jerusalem sixteen years. And unlike David his father, he did not do what was right in the eyes of the LORD. 2 Instead, he walked in the ways of the kings of Israel and even made cast images of the Baals. 3 Moreover, Ahaz burned incense in the Valley of Hinnom and sacrificed his sons in the fire, according to the abominations of the nations that the LORD had driven out before the Israelites. 4 And he sacrificed and burned incense on the high places, on the hills, and under every green tree. 5 So the LORD his God delivered Ahaz into the hand of the king of Aram, who attacked him and took many captives to Damascus. Ahaz was also delivered into the hand of the king of Israel, who struck him with great force. 6 For in one day Pekah son of Remaliah killed 120,000 valiant men in Judah. This happened because they had forsaken the LORD, the God of their fathers. 7 Zichri, a mighty man of Ephraim, killed Maaseiah the son of the king, Azrikam the governor of the palace, and Elkanah the second to the king. 8 Then the Israelites took 200,000 captives from their kinsmen—women, sons, and daughters. They also carried off a great deal of plunder and brought it to Samaria.

9 But a prophet of the LORD named Oded was there, and he went out to meet the army that returned to Samaria. "Look," he said to them, "because of His wrath against Judah, the LORD, the God of your fathers, has delivered them into your hand. But you have slaughtered them in a rage that reaches up to heaven." 10 And now you intend to reduce to slavery the men and women of Judah and Jerusalem. But are you not also guilty before the LORD your God? 11 "Now therefore, listen to me and return the captives you took from your kinsmen, for the fierce anger of the LORD is upon you." 12 Then some of the leaders of the Ephraimites—Azariah son of Jehohanan, Berechiah son of Meshillemoth, Jehizkiah son of Shallum, and Amasa son of Hadlai—stood in opposition to those arriving from the war. 13 "You must not bring the captives here," they said, "for you are proposing to bring guilt upon us from the LORD and to add to our sins and our guilt. For our guilt is great, and fierce anger is upon Israel."

14 So the armed men left the captives and the plunder before the leaders and all the assembly. 15 Then the men who were designated by name arose, took charge of the captives, and provided from the plunder clothing for the naked. They clothed them, gave them sandals and food and drink, anointed their wounds, and put all the feeble on donkeys. So they brought them to Jericho, the City of Palms, to their brothers. Then they returned to Samaria. 16 At that time King Ahaz sent for help from the king of Assyria. 17 The Edomites had again come and attacked Judah and carried away captives.

18 The Philistines had also raided the cities of the foothills and the Negev of Judah, capturing and occupying Beth-shemesh, Aijalon, and Gederoth, as well as Soco, Timnah, and Gimzo with their villages. 19 For the LORD humbled Judah because Ahaz king of Israel had thrown off restraint in Judah and had been most unfaithful to the LORD. 20 Then Tiglath-pileser king of Assyria came to Ahaz but afflicted him rather than strengthening him. 21 Although Ahaz had taken a portion from the house of the LORD, from the royal palace, and from the princes and had presented it to the king of Assyria, it did not help him. 22 In the time of his distress, King Ahaz became even more unfaithful to the LORD. 23 Since Damascus had defeated him, he sacrificed to their gods and said, "Because the gods of the kings of Aram have helped them, I will sacrifice to them that they may help me." But these gods were the downfall of Ahaz and of all Israel. 24 Then Ahaz gathered up the articles of the house of God, cut them into pieces, shut the doors of the house of the LORD, and set up altars of his own on every street corner in Jerusalem. 25 In every city of Judah he built high places to offer incense to other gods, and so he provoked the LORD, the God of his fathers. 26 As for the rest of the acts of Ahaz and all his ways, from beginning to end, they are indeed written in the Book of the Kings of Judah and Israel. 27 And Ahaz rested with his fathers and was buried in the city of Jerusalem, but he was not placed in the tombs of the kings of Israel. And his son Hezekiah reigned in his place.

29 Hezekiah was twenty-five years old when he became king, and he reigned in Jerusalem twenty-nine years. His mother's name was Abijah, the daughter of Zechariah. 2 And he did what was right in the eyes of the LORD, just as his father David had done. 3 In the first month of the first year of his reign, Hezekiah opened and repaired the doors of the house of the LORD. 4 Then he brought in the priests and Levites and gathered them in the square on the east side. 5 "Listen to me, O Levites," he said. "Consecrate yourselves now and consecrate the house of the LORD, the God of your fathers. Remove from the Holy Place every impurity." 6 For our fathers were unfaithful and did evil in the sight of the LORD our God. They abandoned Him, turned their faces away from the dwelling place of the LORD, and turned their backs on Him. 7 They also shut the doors of the portico and extinguished the lamps. They did not burn incense or present burnt offerings in the Holy Place of the God of Israel. 8 Therefore, the wrath of the LORD has fallen upon Judah and Jerusalem, and He has made them an object of terror, horror, and mockery, as you can see with your own eyes. 9 For behold, this is why our fathers have fallen by the sword, and our sons and daughters and wives are in captivity. 10 Now it is in my heart to make a covenant with the LORD, the God of Israel, so that His fierce anger will turn away from us. 11 "Now, my sons, do not be negligent, for the LORD has chosen you to stand before Him, to serve Him, to minister before Him, and to burn incense."

12 Then the Levites set to work: Mahath son of Amasai and Joel son of Azariah from the Kohathites; Kish son of Abdi and Azariah son of Jehallelel from the Merarites; Joah son of Zimmah and Eden son of Joah from the Gershonites; 13 Shimri and Jeuel from the Elizaphanites; Zechariah and Mattaniah from the Asaphites; 14 Jehiel and Shimei from the Hemanites; and Shemaiah and Uzziel from the Jeduthunites. 15 When they had assembled their brothers and consecrated themselves, they went in to cleanse the house of the LORD, according to the command of the king by the words of the LORD. 16 So the priests went inside the house of the LORD to cleanse it, and they brought out to the courtyard all the unclean things that they found in the temple of the LORD. Then the Levites took these things and carried them out to the Kidron Valley. 17 They began the consecration on the first day of the first month, and on the eighth day of the month they reached the portico of the LORD. For eight more days they consecrated the house of the LORD itself, finishing on the sixteenth day of the first month. 18 Then they went in to King Hezekiah and reported, "We have cleansed the entire house of the LORD, the altar of burnt offering with all its utensils, and the table of the showbread with all its utensils." 19 "Moreover, we have prepared and consecrated all the articles that King Ahaz in his unfaithfulness cast aside during his reign. They are now in front of the altar of the LORD." 20 Early the next morning King Hezekiah gathered the city officials and went up to the house of the LORD. 21 They brought seven bulls, seven rams, seven lambs, and seven male goats as a sin offering for the kingdom, for the sanctuary, and for Judah. And the king commanded the priests, the descendants of Aaron, to offer them on the altar of the LORD. 22 So they slaughtered the bulls, and the priests took the blood and sprinkled it on the altar. They slaughtered the rams and sprinkled the blood on the altar. And they slaughtered the lambs and sprinkled the blood on the altar. 23 Then they brought the goats for the sin offering before the king and the assembly, who laid their hands on them.

24 And the priests slaughtered the goats and put their blood on the altar for a sin offering, to make atonement for all Israel, because the king had ordered the burnt offering and the sin offering for all Israel. 25 Hezekiah stationed the Levites in the house of the LORD with cymbals, harps, and lyres according to the command of David, of Gad the king's seer, and of Nathan the prophet. For the command had come from the LORD through His prophets. 26 The Levites stood with the instruments of David, and the priests with the trumpets.

27 And Hezekiah ordered that the burnt offering be sacrificed on the altar. When the burnt offering began, the song of the LORD and the trumpets began as well, accompanied by the instruments of David king of Israel. 28 The whole assembly was worshiping, the singers were singing, and the trumpeters were playing. All this continued until the burnt offering was completed. 29 When the offerings were completed, the king and all those present with him bowed down and worshiped. 30 Then King Hezekiah and his officials ordered the Levites to sing praises to the LORD in the words of David and of Asaph the seer. So they sang praises with gladness and bowed their heads and worshiped. 31 Then Hezekiah said, "Now that you have consecrated yourselves to the LORD, come near and bring sacrifices and thank offerings to the house of the LORD." So the assembly brought sacrifices and thank offerings, and all whose hearts were

willing brought burnt offerings. [32] The number of burnt offerings the assembly brought was seventy bulls, a hundred rams, and two hundred lambs; all these were for a burnt offering to the LORD. [33] And the consecrated offerings were six hundred bulls and three thousand sheep. [34] However, since there were not enough priests to skin all the burnt offerings, their Levite brothers helped them until the work was finished and until the priests had been consecrated. For the Levites had been more diligent in consecrating themselves than the priests had been. [35] Furthermore, the burnt offerings were abundant, along with the fat of the peace offerings and the drink offerings for the burnt offerings. So the service of the house of the LORD was established. [36] Then Hezekiah and all the people rejoiced at what God had prepared for the people, because everything had been accomplished so quickly.

30 Then Hezekiah sent word throughout all Israel and Judah, and he also wrote letters to Ephraim and Manasseh inviting them to come to the house of the LORD in Jerusalem to keep the Passover of the LORD, the God of Israel. [2] For the king and his officials and the whole assembly in Jerusalem had decided to keep the Passover in the second month, [3] since they had been unable to observe it at the regular time, because not enough priests had consecrated themselves and the people had not been gathered in Jerusalem. [4] This proposal pleased the king and the whole assembly. [5] So they established a decree to circulate a proclamation throughout Israel, from Beersheba to Dan, that the people should come to keep the Passover of the LORD, the God of Israel, in Jerusalem. For they had not observed it as a nation as prescribed. [6] So the couriers went throughout Israel and Judah with letters from the king and his officials, which read: "Children of Israel, return to the LORD, the God of Abraham, Isaac, and Israel, so that He may return to those of you who remain, who have escaped the grasp of the kings of Assyria." [7] Do not be like your fathers and brothers who were unfaithful to the LORD, the God of their fathers, so that He made them an object of horror, as you can see. [8] Now do not stiffen your necks as your fathers did. Submit to the LORD and come to His sanctuary, which He has consecrated forever. Serve the LORD your God, so that His fierce anger will turn away from you.

[9] "For if you return to the LORD, your brothers and sons will receive mercy in the presence of their captors and will return to this land. For the LORD your God is gracious and merciful; He will not turn His face away from you if you return to Him." [10] And the couriers traveled from city to city through the land of Ephraim and Manasseh as far as Zebulun; but the people scorned and mocked them. [11] Nevertheless, some from Asher, Manasseh, and Zebulun humbled themselves and came to Jerusalem. [12] Moreover, the power of God was on the people in Judah to give them one heart to obey the command of the king and his officials according to the word of the LORD. [13] In the second month, a very great assembly gathered in Jerusalem to celebrate the Feast of Unleavened Bread. [14] They proceeded to remove the altars in Jerusalem and to take away the incense altars and throw them into the Kidron Valley.

[15] And on the fourteenth day of the second month they slaughtered the Passover lamb. The priests and Levites were ashamed, and they consecrated themselves and brought burnt offerings to the house of the LORD. [16] They stood at their prescribed posts, according to the Law of Moses the man of God. The priests sprinkled the blood, which they received from the hand of the Levites. [17] Since there were many in the assembly who had not consecrated themselves, the Levites were in charge of slaughtering the Passover lambs for every unclean person to consecrate the lambs to the LORD.

[18] A large number of the people—many from Ephraim, Manasseh, Issachar, and Zebulun—had not purified themselves, yet they ate the Passover, contrary to what was written. But Hezekiah interceded for them, saying, "May the LORD, who is good, provide atonement for everyone" [19] "who sets his heart on seeking God—the LORD, the God of his fathers—even if he is not cleansed according to the purification rules of the sanctuary." [20] And the LORD heard Hezekiah and healed the people. [21] The Israelites who were present in Jerusalem celebrated the Feast of Unleavened Bread for seven days with great joy, and the Levites and priests praised the LORD day after day, accompanied by loud instruments of praise to the LORD. [22] And Hezekiah encouraged all the Levites who performed skillfully before the LORD. For seven days they ate their assigned portion, sacrificing fellowship offerings and giving thanks to the LORD, the God of their fathers. [23] The whole assembly agreed to observe seven more days, so they observed seven days with joy. [24] For Hezekiah king of Judah contributed a thousand bulls and seven thousand sheep for the assembly, and the officials contributed a thousand bulls and ten thousand sheep for the assembly, and a great number of priests consecrated themselves. [25] Then the whole assembly of Judah rejoiced along with the priests and Levites and the whole assembly that had come from Israel, including the foreigners who had come from Israel and those who lived in Judah. [26] So there was great rejoicing in Jerusalem, for nothing like this had happened there since the days of Solomon son of David king of Israel. [27] Then the priests and the Levites stood to bless the people, and God heard their voice, and their prayer came into His holy dwelling place in heaven.

31 When all this had ended, the Israelites in attendance went out to the cities of Judah and broke up the sacred pillars, chopped down the Asherah poles, and tore down the high places and altars throughout Judah and Benjamin, as well as in Ephraim and Manasseh, until they had utterly destroyed them all. Then all the Israelites returned to their cities, each to his own property. [2] Hezekiah reestablished the divisions of the priests and Levites—each of them according to their duties as priests or Levites—for the burnt offerings and peace offerings, for ministry, for giving thanks, and for singing praises at the gates of the LORD's dwelling. [3] The king contributed from his own possessions for the regular morning and evening burnt offerings and for the burnt offerings on the Sabbaths, New Moons, and appointed feasts, as written in the Law of the LORD. [4] Moreover, he commanded the people living in Jerusalem to make a contribution for the priests and Levites so that they could devote themselves to the Law of the LORD. [5] As soon as the order went out, the Israelites generously provided the firstfruits of the grain, new wine, oil, and honey, and of all the produce of the field, and they brought in an abundance—a tithe of everything. [6] And the Israelites and Judahites who lived in the cities of Judah also brought a tithe of their herds and flocks and a tithe of the holy things consecrated to the LORD their God, and they laid them in large heaps.

[7] In the third month they began building up the heaps, and they finished in the seventh month. [8] When Hezekiah and his officials came and viewed the heaps, they blessed the LORD and His people Israel. [9] Then Hezekiah questioned the priests and Levites about the heaps, [10] and Azariah, the chief priest of the household of Zadok, answered him, "Since the people began to bring their contributions into the house of the LORD, we have had enough to eat and there is plenty left over, because the LORD has blessed His people; this great abundance is what is left over."

[11] Then Hezekiah commanded them to prepare storerooms in the house of the LORD, and they did so. [12] And they faithfully brought in the contributions, tithes, and dedicated gifts. Conaniah the Levite was the officer in charge of them, and his brother Shimei was second. [13] Jehiel, Azaziah, Nahath, Asahel, Jerimoth, Jozabad, Eliel, Ismachiah, Mahath, and Benaiah were overseers under the authority of Conaniah and his brother Shimei, by appointment of King Hezekiah and of Azariah the chief official of the house of God.

[14] Kore son of Imnah the Levite, the keeper of the East Gate, was in charge of the freewill offerings given to God, distributing the contributions to the LORD and the consecrated gifts. [15] Under his authority, Eden, Miniamin, Jeshua, Shemaiah, Amariah, and Shecaniah faithfully distributed portions to their fellow priests in their cities, according to their divisions, old and young alike. [16] In addition, they distributed portions to the males registered by genealogy who were three years of age or older—to all who would enter the house of the LORD for their daily duties for service in the responsibilities of their divisions— [17] and to the priests enrolled according to their families in the genealogy, as well as to the Levites twenty years of age or older, according to their duties and divisions. [18] The genealogy included all the little ones, wives, sons, and daughters in the whole assembly. For they had faithfully consecrated themselves as holy. [19] As for the priests, the descendants of Aaron, who lived on the farmlands around each of their cities or in any other city, men were designated by name to distribute a portion to every male among the priests and to every Levite listed by the genealogies. [20] So this is what Hezekiah did throughout Judah. He did what was good and upright and true before the LORD his God. [21] He was diligent in every work that he began in the service of the house of God, and in the law and the commandments, in order to seek his God. And so he prospered.

32 After all these acts of faithfulness, Sennacherib king of Assyria came and invaded Judah. He laid siege to the fortified cities, intending to conquer them for himself. [2] When Hezekiah saw that Sennacherib had come to make war against Jerusalem, [3] he consulted with his leaders and commanders about stopping up the waters of the springs outside the city, and they helped him carry it out. [4] Many people assembled and stopped up all the springs and the stream that flowed through the land. "Why should the kings of Assyria come and find plenty of water?" they said. [5] Then Hezekiah worked resolutely to rebuild all the broken sections of the wall and to raise up towers on it. He also built an outer wall and reinforced the supporting terraces of the City of David, and he produced an abundance of weapons and shields. [6] Hezekiah appointed military commanders over the people and gathered the people in the square of the city gate. Then he encouraged them, saying, [7] "Be strong and courageous! Do not be afraid or discouraged before the king of Assyria and the vast army with him, for there is a greater One with us than with him." [8] "With him is only the arm of flesh, but with us is the LORD our God to help us and to fight our battles." So the people were strengthened by the words of Hezekiah king of Judah. [9] Later, as Sennacherib king of Assyria and all his forces besieged Lachish, he sent his servants to Jerusalem with a message for King Hezekiah of Judah and all the people of Judah who were in Jerusalem: [10] "This is what Sennacherib king of Assyria says: What is the basis of your confidence, that you remain in Jerusalem under siege?"

[11] Is not Hezekiah misleading you to give you over to death by famine and thirst when he says, 'The LORD our God will deliver us from the hand of the king of Assyria?' [12] Did not Hezekiah himself remove His high places and His altars and say to Judah and Jerusalem, 'You must worship before one altar, and on it you shall burn sacrifices'? [13] Do you not know what I and my fathers have done to all the peoples of the lands? Have the gods of these nations ever been able to deliver their land from my hand? [14] Who among all the gods of these nations that my fathers devoted to destruction has been able to deliver his people from my hand? How then can your God deliver you from my hand? [15] "So now, do not let Hezekiah deceive you, and do not let him mislead you like this. Do not believe him, for no god of any nation or kingdom has been able to deliver his people from

my hand or from the hand of my fathers. How much less will your God deliver you from my hand!" [16] And the servants of Sennacherib spoke further against the LORD God and against His servant Hezekiah. [17] He also wrote letters mocking the LORD, the God of Israel, and saying against Him: "Just as the gods of the nations did not deliver their people from my hand, so the God of Hezekiah will not deliver His people from my hand." [18] Then the Assyrians called out loudly in Hebrew to the people of Jerusalem who were on the wall, to frighten and terrify them in order to capture the city. [19] They spoke against the God of Jerusalem as they had spoken against the gods of the peoples of the earth—the work of human hands. [20] In response, King Hezekiah and the prophet Isaiah son of Amoz cried out to heaven in prayer, [21] and the LORD sent an angel who annihilated every mighty man of valor and every leader and commander in the camp of the king of Assyria. So he withdrew to his own land in disgrace. And when he entered the temple of his god, some of his own sons struck him down with the sword.

[22] So the LORD saved Hezekiah and the people of Jerusalem from the hands of King Sennacherib of Assyria and all the others, and He gave them rest on every side. [23] Many brought offerings to Jerusalem for the LORD and valuable gifts for Hezekiah king of Judah, and from then on he was exalted in the eyes of all nations. [24] In those days Hezekiah became mortally ill. So he prayed to the LORD, who spoke to him and gave him a sign. [25] But because his heart was proud, Hezekiah did not repay the favor shown to him. Therefore wrath came upon him and upon Judah and Jerusalem. [26] Then Hezekiah humbled the pride of his heart—he and the people of Jerusalem—so that the wrath of the LORD did not come upon them during the days of Hezekiah. [27] Hezekiah had very great riches and honor, and he made treasuries for his silver, gold, precious stones, spices, shields, and all kinds of valuable articles. [28] He also made storehouses for the harvest of grain and new wine and oil, stalls for all kinds of livestock, and pens for the flocks. [29] He made cities for himself, and he acquired herds of sheep and cattle in abundance, for God gave him very great wealth. [30] It was Hezekiah who blocked the upper outlet of the Spring of Gihon and channeled it down to the west side of the City of David. And Hezekiah prospered in all that he did. [31] And so when ambassadors of the rulers of Babylon were sent to him to inquire about the wonder that had happened in the land, God left him alone to test him, that He might know all that was in Hezekiah's heart. [32] As for the rest of the acts of Hezekiah and his deeds of loving devotion, they are indeed written in the vision of the prophet Isaiah son of Amoz in the Book of the Kings of Judah and Israel. [33] And Hezekiah rested with his fathers and was buried in the upper tombs of David's descendants. All Judah and the people of Jerusalem paid him honor at his death. And his son Manasseh reigned in his place.

33 Manasseh was twelve years old when he became king, and he reigned in Jerusalem fifty-five years. [2] And he did evil in the sight of the LORD by following the abominations of the nations that the LORD had driven out before the Israelites. [3] For he rebuilt the high places that his father Hezekiah had torn down, and he raised up altars for the Baals and made Asherah poles. And he worshiped and served all the host of heaven. [4] Manasseh also built altars in the house of the LORD, of which the LORD had said, "My Name will remain in Jerusalem forever." [5] In both courtyards of the house of the LORD, he built altars to all the host of heaven. [6] He sacrificed his sons in the fire in the Valley of Hinnom. He practiced sorcery, divination, and witchcraft, and consulted mediums and spiritists. He did great evil in the sight of the LORD, provoking Him to anger. [7] Manasseh even took the carved image he had made and set it up in the house of God, of which God had said to David and his son Solomon, "In this temple and in Jerusalem, which I have chosen out of all the tribes of Israel, I will establish My Name forever."

[8] "I will never again cause the feet of the Israelites to leave the land that I assigned to your fathers, if only they are careful to do all that I have commanded them through Moses—all the laws, statutes, and judgments." [9] So Manasseh led the people of Judah and Jerusalem astray, so that they did greater evil than the nations that the LORD had destroyed before the Israelites. [10] And the LORD spoke to Manasseh and his people, but they did not listen. [11] So the LORD brought against them the military commanders of the king of Assyria, who captured Manasseh, put a hook in his nose, bound him with bronze shackles, and took him to Babylon. [12] And in his distress, Manasseh sought the favor of the LORD his God and earnestly humbled himself before the God of his fathers.

[13] And when he prayed to Him, the LORD received his plea and heard his petition; so He brought him back to Jerusalem and to his kingdom. Then Manasseh knew that the LORD is God. [14] After this, Manasseh rebuilt the outer wall of the City of David from west of Gihon in the valley to the entrance of the Fish Gate, and he brought it around the hill of Ophel and heightened it considerably. He also stationed military commanders in all the fortified cities of Judah. [15] He removed the foreign gods and the idol from the house of the LORD, along with all the altars he had built on the temple mount and in Jerusalem, and he dumped them outside the city.

[16] Then he restored the altar of the LORD and sacrificed peace offerings and thank offerings on it, and he told Judah to serve the LORD, the God of Israel. [17] Nevertheless, the people still sacrificed at the high places, but only to the LORD their God. [18] As for the rest of the acts of Manasseh, along with his prayer to his God and the words of the seers who spoke to him in the name of the LORD, the God of Israel, they are indeed written in the Chronicles of the Kings of Israel. [19] His prayer and how God received his plea, as well as all his sin and unfaithfulness, and the sites where he built high places and set up Asherah poles and idols before he humbled himself, they are indeed written in the Records of the Seers. [20] And Manasseh rested with his fathers and was buried at his palace. And his son Amon reigned in his place. [21] Amon was twenty-two years old when he became king, and he reigned in Jerusalem two years. [22] And he did evil in the sight of the LORD, as his father Manasseh had done. Amon served and sacrificed to all the idols that his father Manasseh had made, [23] but he did not humble himself before the LORD as his father Manasseh had done; instead, Amon increased his guilt. [24] Then the servants of Amon conspired against him and killed him in his palace. [25] But the people of the land killed all those who had conspired against King Amon, and they made his son Josiah king in his place.

34 Josiah was eight years old when he became king, and he reigned in Jerusalem thirty-one years. [2] And he did what was right in the eyes of the LORD and walked in the ways of his father David; he did not turn aside to the right or to the left. [3] In the eighth year of his reign, while he was still young, Josiah began to seek the God of his father David, and in the twelfth year he began to cleanse Judah and Jerusalem of the high places, the Asherah poles, the carved idols, and the cast images. [4] Then in his presence the altars of the Baals were torn down, and he cut to pieces the incense altars that were above them. He shattered the Asherah poles, the carved idols, and the cast images, crushed them to dust, and scattered them over the graves of those who had sacrificed to them. [5] Then he burned the bones of the priests on their altars. So he cleansed Judah and Jerusalem. [6] Josiah did the same in the cities of Manasseh, Ephraim, and Simeon, as far as Naphtali, and in the ruins around them. [7] He tore down the altars and Asherah poles, crushed the idols to powder, and cut to pieces all the incense altars throughout the land of Israel. Then he returned to Jerusalem. [8] Now in the eighteenth year of his reign, in order to cleanse the land and the temple, Josiah sent Shaphan son of Azaliah, Maaseiah the governor of the city, and Joah son of Joahaz, the recorder, to repair the house of the LORD his God. [9] So they went to Hilkiah the high priest and gave him the money that had been brought into the house of God, which the Levites at the doors had collected from the people of Manasseh and Ephraim, from all the remnant of Israel, Judah, and Benjamin, and from the people of Jerusalem. [10] They put it into the hands of the supervisors of those doing the work of the house of the LORD, who in turn gave it to the workmen restoring and repairing the house of the LORD.

[11] They also gave money to the carpenters and builders to buy dressed stone, as well as timbers for couplings and beams for the buildings that the kings of Judah had allowed to deteriorate. [12] And the men did the work faithfully. The Levites overseeing them were Jahath and Obadiah, descendants of Merari, and Zechariah and Meshullam, descendants of Kohath. Other Levites, all skilled with musical instruments, [13] were over the laborers and supervised all who did the work, task by task. Some of the Levites were secretaries, officers, and gatekeepers. [14] While they were bringing out the money that had been taken into the house of the LORD, Hilkiah the priest found the Book of the Law of the LORD written by Moses. [15] And Hilkiah said to Shaphan the scribe, "I have found the Book of the Law in the house of the LORD!" And he gave it to Shaphan. [16] Then Shaphan brought the book to the king and reported, "Your servants are doing all that has been placed in their hands." [17] "They have paid out the money that was found in the house of the LORD and have put it into the hands of the supervisors and workers." [18] Moreover, Shaphan the scribe told the king, "Hilkiah the priest has given me a book." And Shaphan read it in the presence of the king. [19] When the king heard the words of the Law, he tore his clothes [20] and commanded Hilkiah, Ahikam son of Shaphan, Abdon son of Micah, Shaphan the scribe, and Asaiah the servant of the king: [21] "Go and inquire of the LORD for me and for those remaining in Israel and Judah concerning the words in the book that has been found. For great is the wrath of the LORD that has been poured out on us because our fathers have not kept the word of the LORD by doing all that is written in this book."

[22] So Hilkiah and those the king had designated went and spoke to Huldah the prophetess, the wife of Shallum son of Tokhath, the son of Hasrah, the keeper of the wardrobe. She lived in Jerusalem, in the Second District. [23] And Huldah said to them, "This is what the LORD, the God of Israel, says: 'Tell the man who sent you'" [24] that this is what the LORD says: I am about to bring calamity on this place and on its people, according to all the curses written in the book that has been read in the presence of the king of Judah, [25] because they have forsaken Me and burned incense to other gods, that they might provoke Me to anger with all the works of their hands. My wrath will be poured out upon this place and will not be quenched.' [26] But as for the king of Judah, who sent you to inquire of the LORD, tell him that this is what the LORD, the God of Israel, says: 'As for the words that you heard,' [27] because your heart was tender and you humbled yourself before God when you heard His words against this place and against its people, and because you have humbled yourself before Me and you have torn your clothes and wept before Me, I have heard you,' declares the LORD. [28] "'Now I will indeed gather you to your fathers, and you will be gathered to your grave in peace. Your eyes will not see all the calamity that I will bring on this place and on its inhabitants.'" So they brought her answer back to the king. [29] Then the king summoned all the elders of Judah and Jerusalem. [30] And he went up to the house of the LORD with all the people of Judah and Jerusalem, as well as the priests and the Levites—all the people small and great—and in their hearing he read all the words of the Book of the Covenant that had been found in the house of the LORD. [31] So the king stood by the pillar

and made a covenant before the LORD to follow the LORD and to keep His commandments, decrees, and statutes with all his heart and all his soul, and to carry out the words of this covenant that were written in this book. [32] Then he had everyone in Jerusalem and Benjamin take a stand in agreement to it. So all the people of Jerusalem carried out the covenant of God, the God of their fathers. [33] And Josiah removed all the abominations from all the lands belonging to the Israelites, and he required everyone in Israel to serve the LORD their God. Throughout his reign they did not turn aside from following the LORD, the God of their fathers.

35 Then Josiah celebrated the Passover to the LORD in Jerusalem, and the Passover lamb was slaughtered on the fourteenth day of the first month. [2] He appointed the priests to their duties and encouraged them in the service of the house of the LORD. [3] To the Levites who taught all Israel and were holy to the LORD, Josiah said: "Put the holy ark in the temple built by Solomon son of David king of Israel. It is not to be carried around on your shoulders. Now serve the LORD your God and His people Israel." [4] Prepare yourselves by families in your divisions, according to the instructions written by David king of Israel and Solomon his son. [5] Moreover, stand in the Holy Place by the divisions of the families of your kinsmen the lay people, and by the divisions of the families of the Levites. [6] "Slaughter the Passover lambs, consecrate yourselves, and make preparations for your fellow countrymen to carry out the word of the LORD given by Moses." [7] From his own flocks and herds Josiah contributed 30,000 lambs and goats plus 3,000 bulls for the Passover offerings for all the people who were present. [8] His officials also contributed willingly to the people and priests and Levites. Hilkiah, Zechariah, and Jehiel, the administrators of the house of God, gave the priests 2,600 Passover offerings and 300 bulls.

[9] Additionally, Conaniah and his brothers Shemaiah and Nethanel, as well as Hashabiah, Jeiel, and Jozabad, officers of the Levites, donated to the Levites 5,000 Passover offerings and 500 bulls. [10] So the service was prepared; the priests stood in their places and the Levites in their divisions according to the king's command. [11] And they slaughtered the Passover lambs, while the priests sprinkled the blood handed to them and the Levites skinned the animals. [12] They set aside the burnt offerings to be given to the divisions of the families of the people to offer to the LORD, as is written in the Book of Moses; and they did the same with the bulls. [13] They roasted the Passover animals on the fire according to the regulation, and they boiled the other holy offerings in pots, kettles, and bowls and quickly brought them to all the people. [14] Afterward, they made preparations for themselves and for the priests, since the priests, the descendants of Aaron, were offering up burnt offerings and fat until nightfall. So the Levites made preparations for themselves and for the priests, the descendants of Aaron. [15] The singers, the descendants of Asaph, were at their stations according to the command of David, Asaph, Heman, and Jeduthun the king's seer. And the gatekeepers at each gate did not need to leave their position, because their fellow Levites made preparations for them.

[16] So on that day the entire service of the LORD was carried out for celebrating the Passover and offering burnt offerings on the altar of the LORD, according to the command of King Josiah. [17] The Israelites who were present also observed the Passover at that time, as well as the Feast of Unleavened Bread for seven days.

[18] No such Passover had been observed in Israel since the days of Samuel the prophet. None of the kings of Israel ever observed a Passover like the one that Josiah observed with the priests, the Levites, all Judah, the Israelites who were present, and the people of Jerusalem. [19] In the eighteenth year of Josiah's reign, this Passover was observed. [20] After all this, when Josiah had set the temple in order, Neco king of Egypt marched up to fight at Carchemish by the Euphrates, and Josiah went out to confront him. [21] But Neco sent messengers to him, saying, "What is the issue between you and me, O king of Judah? I have not come against you today, but I am fighting another dynasty. God told me to hurry; so stop opposing God, who is with me, or He will destroy you!" [22] Josiah, however, did not turn away from him; instead, in order to engage him in battle, he disguised himself. He did not listen to Neco's words from the mouth of God, but went to fight him on the Plain of Megiddo. [23] There the archers shot King Josiah, who said to his servants, "Take me away, for I am badly wounded!" [24] So his servants took him out of his chariot, put him in his second chariot, and brought him to Jerusalem, where he died. And Josiah was buried in the tomb of his fathers, and all Judah and Jerusalem mourned for him. [25] Then Jeremiah lamented over Josiah, and to this day all the choirs of men and women sing laments over Josiah. They established them as a statute for Israel, and indeed they are written in the Book of Laments. [26] As for the rest of the acts of Josiah, along with his deeds of loving devotion according to what is written in the Law of the LORD— [27] his acts from beginning to end—they are indeed written in the Book of the Kings of Israel and Judah.

36 Then the people of the land took Jehoahaz son of Josiah and made him king in Jerusalem in place of his father. [2] Jehoahaz was twenty-three years old when he became king, and he reigned in Jerusalem three months. [3] And the king of Egypt dethroned him in Jerusalem and imposed on Judah a levy of a hundred talents of silver and a talent of gold. [4] Then Neco king of Egypt made Eliakim brother of Jehoahaz king over Judah and Jerusalem, and he changed Eliakim's name to Jehoiakim. But Neco took Eliakim's brother Jehoahaz and carried him off to Egypt. [5] Jehoiakim was twenty-five years old when he became king, and he reigned in Jerusalem eleven years. And he did evil in the sight of the LORD his God. [6] Then Nebuchadnezzar king of Babylon came up against Jehoiakim and bound him with bronze shackles to take him to Babylon.

[7] Nebuchadnezzar also took to Babylon some of the articles from the house of the LORD, and he put them in his temple in Babylon. [8] As for the rest of the acts of Jehoiakim, the abominations he committed, and all that was found against him, they are indeed written in the Book of the Kings of Israel and Judah. And his son Jehoiachin reigned in his place. [9] Jehoiachin was eighteen years old when he became king, and he reigned in Jerusalem three months and ten days. And he did evil in the sight of the LORD. [10] In the spring, King Nebuchadnezzar summoned Jehoiachin and brought him to Babylon, along with the articles of value from the house of the LORD. And he made Jehoiachin's relative Zedekiah king over Judah and Jerusalem.

[11] Zedekiah was twenty-one years old when he became king, and he reigned in Jerusalem eleven years. [12] And he did evil in the sight of the LORD his God and did not humble himself before Jeremiah the prophet, who spoke for the LORD. [13] He also rebelled against King Nebuchadnezzar, who had made him swear by God. But Zedekiah stiffened his neck and hardened his heart against turning to the LORD, the God of Israel. [14] Furthermore, all the leaders of the priests and the people multiplied their unfaithful deeds, following all the abominations of the nations, and they defiled the house of the LORD, which He had consecrated in Jerusalem.

[15] Again and again the LORD, the God of their fathers, sent word to His people through His messengers because He had compassion on them and on His dwelling place. [16] But they mocked the messengers of God, despising His words and scoffing at His prophets, until the wrath of the LORD against His people was stirred up beyond remedy. [17] So He brought up against them the king of the Chaldeans, who put their young men to the sword in the sanctuary, sparing neither young men nor young women, neither elderly nor infirm. God gave them all into the hand of Nebuchadnezzar, [18] who carried off everything to Babylon —all the articles of the house of God, both large and small, and the treasures of the house of the LORD and of the king and his officials. [19] Then the Chaldeans set fire to the house of God and broke down the wall of Jerusalem. They burned down all the palaces and destroyed every article of value. [20] Those who escaped the sword were carried by Nebuchadnezzar into exile in Babylon, and they became servants to him and his sons until the kingdom of Persia came to power. [21] So the land enjoyed its Sabbath rest all the days of the desolation, until seventy years were completed, in fulfillment of the word of the LORD through Jeremiah. [22] In the first year of Cyrus king of Persia, to fulfill the word of the LORD spoken through Jeremiah, the LORD stirred the spirit of Cyrus king of Persia to send a proclamation throughout his kingdom and to put it in writing as follows: [23] "This is what Cyrus king of Persia says: 'The LORD, the God of heaven, who has given me all the kingdoms of the earth, has appointed me to build a house for Him at Jerusalem in Judah. Whoever among you belongs to His people, may the LORD his God be with him, and may he go up.'"